The domestication of the camel gave the bedouin great mobility. He could travel 1,500 miles over the desert in 30 days, with a 30-40 lb. sack of flour tied to the camel as his only food. The camel can go 250 miles in three summer days without water, where a single day's travel will kill a horse. The bedouin can therefore raid quickly and -- if need be -- run. Before the days of motor roads across the desert, before armored cars, radio and airplanes, it was hard to organize a quick and effective pursuit.

The kings of Israel and Assyria (and later the Persians and Romans) sent armies into the desert to subdue the warring tribes. They established frontier posts all along the line where the Transjordanian highland dips to the desert. When central government weakened, however, the bedouin broke the frontier and resumed his ascendancy over the villager of the sown. As late as 1921 some 3,000 bedouins on camels raided into Transjordan from Arabia but were broken up by bombing planes and armored cars before reaching Amman.

Throughout history a constant increase or decrease of population can be observed on the edge of the desert. When governments are strong enough to guarantee security of life and property, the herdsmen of goats and sheep are transformed into farmers; they build cottages, hamlets come into existence, and the semi-nomad becomes a peaceful settler. He entrusts his goats and sheep to the care of friendly clans of bedouins, who do not go back to the inner desert but are themselves transformed into semi-nomads. On the other hand, if there is no strong government in the sown, security of life and property disappears. There follows a decrease of population. In the valleys open to raids, settlements are abandoned. On the frontiers of the sown, the permanent house is exchanged for the movable tent. The farmers become semi-nomads.

It is the boast of the Western civilization of the twentieth century that this oscillation of the desert and the sown is being resolved, by its power, for all time, in favor of the sown. The camel markets of Egypt, Palestine, Syria and Iraq -- whose demand determines the population that the deserts can support -- are being extinguished by the automobile and the hard-surface motor road. The